The Robin

By Gore Vidal

I have forgotten whose idea it was first. I hope it was Oliver's. We decided he must be put out of his misery; he must be killed. The decision was made easily enough but when it came to the actual execution we were not only uninventive but frightened.

INTRODUCTION

The power over life and death, the ability to hold the future of another creature in the palm of your hand and decide whether it is worthy of life or should be put to death. In America, some juries are given this dominion over criminals convicted of heinous crimes. Or consider the concept of euthanasia, the practice of killing in a painless or minimally painful way for merciful reasons, usually to end suffering. There are opponents and advocates of both practices and the ethical debate of each situation will rage on for years to come. In The Robin by Gore Vidal, we take a more personal look at this life and death decision.

At nine I was very much tougher than I am now. I enjoyed all sorts of unpleasant things: other people's

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fights (I was early an audience), automobile accidents, stories of suicides and one particular peepshow at an amusement park near Washington where, through holes in a tall imitation stockade, one could observe an immense plaster elephant goring a plaster Hindu. But best of all I liked the magazines sold in drugstores, magazines with pictures of young women entangled in giant spider webs on their covers and, inside, pictures of the most exciting scenes of torture. I used to sit for hours on the tile floor of a certain drugstore and carefully examine the magazines. Sometimes I even read the stories. I liked very much the directness, the naturalness of the style. I had long since become bored with the colorless fourth-grade reader and I hadn't yet discovered the Oz books which, at ten, helped bring to an end my tough period.

In the fourth grade I had one close friend: thin pale-haired, pale-eyed, pale-skinned boy whose name was Oliver. I suppose he has since grown up to become a lawyer or a realtor. Most boys from our group in Washington became either one or the other. To my

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knowledge no one has become anything interesting like a movie star or an artist though a number have been divorced once or twice and several show signs of alcoholism.

Oliver loved violence and torture as much as I did and he was almost as tough as I was, and that was very tough indeed. Our conversation was a mixture of gangster and nursery talk. We organized secret societies, encouraged gang warfare at school, and sometimes we even went to grocery stores and stole.

All of us had elaborate dream worlds. I can guess now what Oliver's was probably like; as for my own, I can remember it vividly: the climate, the scenery and even various plots of my imaginary life when I was nine and depraved. I know I that I had great physical strength and lived in a castle, wore a cloak and very often a crown. I was not only stronger than the other nine-year-olds, I was stronger than grown men too: that deep-voiced, rough-faced alien race. And in my world I invented all sorts of tortures for my enemies. The most constant and satisfactory victim was the fourth-grade

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teacher, a shapeless woman with bobbed hair, gray and untidy, and a dreadful nose that was thin with a pink, translucent membrane. She almost always had a cold and a fever blister on her upper lip. She was stern, malicious and, in moments of anger, an arm-twister. She received her reward in my world.

About the middle of October, shortly after my ninth birthday, on a clear bright afternoon, Oliver and I saw the robin.

First, let me say that our school was what they call a country day school, several miles from the city. The school had broad, well-kept lawns where less imaginative boys resolved their violence in football and fighting. Oliver and I seldom joined them; we were contemptuous of such simplicity. Sometimes of course we were forced to play and when that happened I'd pick a part of the field where nothing much was going to disturb me and here I would stand and daydream. In these dreams I was the actor, never the audience.

The school occupied a large country home in Virginia some ten minutes by bus from Washington. The

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house was what we, in that part of the South, call Georgian though actually it was a gracious late 19th century muddle of styles: red brick, with tall windows on the ground floor and inside, a curving staircase. There were high ceilings, cracks in the walls and everywhere the sense of many generations of Southern feudal life. . . actually, the house was the relic of a rich Northerner who, having come South with a Republican administration, built this house, fancied himself a squire, willed it to his children, died and they, true heirs, promptly sold it.

But to us, to the sixty pupils, the grounds were far more interesting than the house: smooth lawn curved from the house to the line of woods where between thin dark trees bright in autumn with the colors of the fool, one could just make out the brown slow Potomac River which roared continuously, sea-like and far away, a sad lonely sound.

The day of the robin was like any other day of autumn. I caught the school bus in front of my house and talked to Oliver as we drove to school. I haven't the

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faintest idea what our conversations were like when we were nine.

I suppose that Oliver and I discussed our teachers, the other boys and the peculiarities of our parents. I do remember once turning to him and saying solemnly (this was a year later, after my mother's divorce): "We've gone through hell and high water together, my mother and I." By the time I was ten I do recall that I talked almost entirely in sonorous clichés - and I had begun to demonstrate an alarming talent for moral poetry. But at nine, on this sharp October day, I was more colorful, more desperate and certainly more original than I've ever been since.

We arrived at the school, entered the classroom and here recollection ceases. I suppose something must have happened in those classes but I cannot remember what. During the twelve years I spent in schools, I remember almost nothing that happened in the classrooms. I have only one clear memory of my first six years in school. For some reason we built a model of the Appian Way on a card table. And since, among my

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numerous talents, I had a gift for modeling, I was invited to make the human figures for the Appian Way. They were beautiful, splendid Romans, happily proportioned, clothed in togas of the whitest tissue paper. Everyone was impressed. But unfortunately they would not stand up and the teacher, that thin-lipped terrible woman, squashed all the legs down to fat columns, completely ruining their classic symmetry. When I discovered this, I gave such a demonstration of outraged sensibility that she was forced to call in the principal who tried to soothe me by suggesting that with long togas no one would notice the legs and, besides I should remember I had been commissioned to do figures (very admirable they were, too) which could stand up in chariots.

Aside from this one episode I remember nothing of those six years in the classroom but I do remember the afternoons out of doors, especially this particular afternoon in October. The sky was pale and the clouds were heavy and white and they moved so slowly, changed shape so slowly that one was quite hypnotized watching

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the castles become elephants, and the elephants swans and the swans teachers. On this day Oliver and I unobtrusively slipped away from our game-playing classmates.

We walked quickly to the edge of the lawn where a wooded cliff dropped nearly vertical to the river below. Here, hidden from the others by a row of evergreens, the river beneath us, we sat comfortably on the ground and I began to make up a story while Oliver listened eagerly, flatteringly.

It was he who noticed the robin first. "Look he said, interrupting me, pointing at something in the grass. I looked and saw the bird. One of its wings had been broken and it fluttered feebly, still trying to fly. We went over and examined
carefully. Both wary of touching it for fear of an unexpected sting or bite or sinister germs.

"What'll we do?" I asked. One always had to do something about everything that came one's way.

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Oliver shook his head; he was no use. "It's hurt bad." We watched the robin as it fluttered in a small circle on the ground. It made a small piping sound.

"Maybe we ought to take it home." But Oliver shook his head: "It's hurt too bad. It's not going to live long and anyway we wouldn't know what to do."

"Maybe we should get some witch hazel or something," I suggested; but since this meant approaching the authorities of the school, we decided against doctoring.

I have forgotten whose idea it was first. I hope it was Oliver's. We decided the robin must be put out of its misery; it must be killed. The decision was made easily enough but when it came to the actual execution we were not only uninventive but frightened.

Thinking of a picture I had seen of Saint Stephen, I suggested the robin be killed with stone. Oliver took the first stone (I'm almost certain it was Oliver) and dropped it directly on top of the creature, but the stone fell to one side and the bird, still alive, fluttered its wings and gasped. Then I took a stone and

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dropped it and now, horribly, there was blood on the wings that fluttered in the bright air, that fanned the dead leaves on the ground.

Then we grew frightened and angry and we took more stones and threw them as hard as we could at the robin, anything to stop the motion of those wings and the sound of pain. The stones fell one upon another until the bird was covered except for its head . . . and still it was not dead: it would not die. Oliver (I am sure now it was Oliver) finally took a very large stone and smashed it as hard as he could on top of the pyramid, finishing the tomb. Then we listened carefully: there were no more sounds from within.

We stood for a long time, not looking at one another, the pile of stones between us. No sound but the distant shouts of our classmates playing on the lawn. The sun shone brilliantly; nothing had changed in the world but suddenly, without a word and at the same moment, we both began to cry.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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